HER METHOD

The

Glute Growth Guide

The science-backed approach to building stronger, rounder glutes — sustainably.

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evidence-based · sustainable · science-backed

Welcome to Your Glute Growth Guide

from Khiana Smith, Her Method

Hey! I'm so glad you're here.

Building your glutes is one of the most rewarding things you can do in your fitness journey — but it's also one of the most misunderstood. If you've been training consistently and not seeing the results you want, this guide is for you.

Inside, I'm going to break down exactly why glute growth happens, what's been holding you back, which exercises actually work (and why), and give you a real program to follow — one that's built on science, not social media trends.

This is the Her Method approach: evidence-based, sustainable, and designed for real women living real lives.

Let's build something strong. — Khiana x

Chapter One

How Glutes Actually Grow

Before we talk about exercises and programs, you need to understand the basics of muscle growth — because without this foundation, you'll keep spinning your wheels.

The Science of Hypertrophy

Muscle growth (hypertrophy) happens when you apply a stimulus to a muscle that causes microscopic damage to the muscle fibres. Your body repairs those fibres, and in doing so, makes them slightly thicker and stronger than before. Over time, with consistent training and adequate recovery, this adds up to visible growth.

For this process to work, three things need to be in place:

- Mechanical tension — the load or force placed on the muscle during an exercise
- Metabolic stress — the 'burn' and pump you feel during higher rep sets
- Muscle damage — the micro-tears that signal your body to repair and rebuild

Glute training needs to hit all three to be truly effective.

The Glute Anatomy You Actually Need to Know

Your glutes are made up of three muscles, and understanding them helps you train smarter:

- Gluteus Maximus — the largest muscle, responsible for hip extension. This is what gives you that rounded shape and is targeted with exercises like hip thrusts and squats.
- Gluteus Medius — sits on the outer hip. Responsible for hip abduction (moving your leg out to the side). Targeted with exercises like lateral band walks and hip abductions.
- Gluteus Minimus — the smallest, sits beneath the medius. Works alongside the medius for stability and abduction.

Most women focus only on the maximus (the big one) and neglect the medius — which is why they end up with glutes that lack roundness and width. A complete program trains all three.

Her Method Key Point

Your glutes are the largest muscle group in your body. They respond best to a mix of heavy compound movements (for tension) and isolation exercises (for targeted growth). One approach alone won't get you the results you want.

Chapter Two

Why Your Glutes Aren't Growing

This is the chapter most people need. If you've been training for months and your glutes look the same, one or more of these is the reason why.

1. You're Not In a Calorie Surplus (or Eating Enough Protein)

Muscle growth requires resources. If you're eating in a calorie deficit or at maintenance, your body has limited capacity to build new tissue. This doesn't mean you need to bulk aggressively — a small surplus of 100–200 calories above maintenance is enough. But chronically undereating while trying to grow is fighting against your own biology.

Protein is equally critical. Aim for 1.6–2.2g of protein per kilogram of body weight daily. This gives your body the building blocks (amino acids) it needs to repair and build muscle after training.

2. You're Not Progressively Overloading

Progressive overload means consistently increasing the challenge placed on your muscles over time. This is the single most important training principle for growth, and it's the one most women skip.

If you're doing the same weights, the same reps, the same exercises week after week — your glutes have no reason to grow. They've adapted to that stimulus. You need to keep pushing.

Progressive overload can look like:

- Adding weight to the bar
- Adding more reps with the same weight
- Adding an extra set
- Slowing down your tempo (more time under tension)
- Reducing rest time

3. You're Not Feeling Your Glutes Working

The mind-muscle connection is real, and it matters. If your quads are taking over every squat and your lower back is doing the work in your hip thrusts, your glutes won't be the ones growing.

Before every workout, spend 5 minutes activating your glutes with bodyweight exercises. This wakes them up and helps you connect to them during your main lifts.

4. You're Not Training With Enough Volume or Frequency

Research suggests that glutes respond well to higher training volume — roughly 10–20 working sets per week is the sweet spot for most people. Training them only once a week is likely not enough stimulus for meaningful growth.

Aim to train your glutes 2–3 times per week, with at least 48 hours of recovery between sessions.

5. You're Doing Too Much Cardio and Not Recovering

Cardio isn't the enemy, but excessive cardio on top of a training program can interfere with muscle building — especially if your nutrition isn't dialled in. Recovery happens outside the gym. If you're constantly sore, not sleeping well, or stressed, your body will struggle to build muscle regardless of how hard you train.

> **Her Method Key Point**
>
> Growth happens during recovery, not during the workout itself. Training is just the stimulus. Nutrition, sleep, and stress management are what allow your body to actually make changes.

Chapter Three

The Best Exercises for Glute Growth

Not all glute exercises are created equal. Here's a breakdown of the most effective movements, why they work, and how to do them well.

Tier 1: High Priority Exercises

These are your non-negotiables — the movements that should form the backbone of every glute program.

Hip Thrust

Widely considered the most effective glute exercise. The barbell hip thrust places the glute maximus under peak tension at full hip extension — the position where it's strongest. This makes it uniquely effective for building size and strength.

Key technique cues:

- Drive through your heels, not your toes
- At the top, squeeze hard and hold for 1–2 seconds
- Keep your chin tucked and core braced throughout
- Your shins should be roughly vertical at the top of the movement

Romanian Deadlift (RDL)

The RDL is a hip hinge movement that loads the glutes under a stretch at the bottom — a different stimulus to the hip thrust. This combination of stretch and tension makes it extremely effective for glute development.

Key technique cues:

- Hinge at the hips, not the waist — push your hips back
- Keep a neutral spine throughout
- Feel a stretch in your hamstrings and glutes at the bottom
- Drive your hips forward to stand, squeezing glutes at the top

Bulgarian Split Squat

A single-leg exercise that creates high levels of tension through the glutes and also helps correct any strength imbalances between legs. Yes, they're hard. Yes, they work.

Key technique cues:

- Keep your front foot far enough forward that your torso stays upright
- Drive through your front heel
- Lower slowly and with control
- Lean slightly forward for more glute activation

Tier 2: Important Supporting Exercises

Cable or Banded Hip Abduction

Directly targets the gluteus medius and minimus. Essential for building the outer roundness of the glutes that squats and hip thrusts alone won't give you.

Glute Bridge (Bodyweight or Banded)

A great activation exercise before training and a solid accessory movement. Works similarly to the hip thrust but with less load — useful for higher rep, pump-focused sets.

Sumo Deadlift

The wider stance of a sumo deadlift shifts more emphasis onto the glutes compared to a conventional stance. A great heavy compound movement to rotate in with RDLs.

Step-Ups

Underrated and underused. Step-ups are a unilateral exercise that loads the glutes similarly to a split squat. Add a weight and go slowly for maximum effect.

Tier 3: Activation & Warm-Up

Always do 5–10 minutes of glute activation before your main session:

- Clamshells — 2 x 15–20 each side
- Lateral band walks — 2 x 15 each direction
- Donkey kicks — 2 x 15 each side
- Bodyweight glute bridges — 2 x 20

Chapter Four

Progressive Overload — Your Growth Engine

We touched on progressive overload earlier, but it's important enough to deserve its own chapter. This is the principle that separates women who see results from women who plateau.

Here's the simple rule: your muscles will only grow if they are forced to do more than they're used to. Once they've adapted to a given stimulus, that stimulus no longer causes growth.

How to Track Progress

You cannot progressively overload without tracking. This doesn't need to be complicated — a notes app on your phone works perfectly. After every session, record:

- The exercise
- The weight used
- The number of sets and reps completed

At your next session, aim to beat at least one of those numbers. Even adding one rep to one set counts as progress.

The Double Progression Method

1. Choose a rep range for each exercise (e.g. 8–12 reps)
2. Start with a weight where you can do the minimum (e.g. 8 reps) with good form
3. Each week, try to add reps until you hit the top of the range (e.g. 12 reps)
4. Once you can do all sets at 12 reps, add weight and start again from the bottom

> **Her Method Key Point**
>
> Progressive overload is non-negotiable. If you're not tracking your lifts, you're guessing — and guessing doesn't build glutes. Even a basic notes app is enough. Start logging today.

Chapter Five

Your 4-Week Glute Program

This program is designed to be run 3 days per week. Each session has a slightly different emphasis so you're developing your glutes from multiple angles without overtraining.

Rest at least one full day between each session. Each week, aim to add reps or weight where possible.

Day A — Glute Maximus Focus · Day B — Medius & Stability · Day C — Full Development

Example weekly schedule: Monday (A) · Wednesday (B) · Friday (C)

Day A — Glute Maximus Focus

Activation: 5 mins of clamshells, glute bridges, lateral band walks

Exercise	Sets	Reps	Rest
Barbell Hip Thrust	4	8–12	90 sec
Romanian Deadlift	3	10–12	90 sec
Leg Press (feet high)	3	12–15	60 sec
Cable Kickback	3	12–15 each	60 sec
Glute Bridge (banded)	2	20–25	45 sec

Day B — Medius & Stability Focus

Activation: 5 mins of donkey kicks, clamshells, lateral band walks

Exercise	Sets	Reps	Rest
Bulgarian Split Squat	4	10–12 each	90 sec
Cable Hip Abduction	4	15–20 each	60 sec
Step-Ups (weighted)	3	12 each	75 sec
Lateral Band Walk	3	15 each way	45 sec
Single-Leg Glute Bridge	3	15 each	45 sec

Day C — Full Glute Development

Activation: 5 mins of full activation circuit

Exercise	Sets	Reps	Rest
Sumo Deadlift	4	6–8	2 min
Hip Thrust (pause at top)	3	10–12	90 sec
Goblet Squat (deep)	3	12–15	75 sec
Banded Clamshell	3	20 each	45 sec
RDL (single leg)	3	10–12 each	60 sec

Chapter Six

Nutrition for Glute Growth

You can train perfectly and still not see results if your nutrition isn't supporting your goals. Here's what actually matters.

Protein — Your Non-Negotiable

Protein is the building block of muscle. Without adequate protein, your body can't repair and build the muscle fibres you're breaking down in training.

Target: 1.6–2.2g of protein per kg of bodyweight daily.

For a 65kg woman, that's 104–143g of protein per day. Spread this across 3–4 meals for optimal muscle protein synthesis throughout the day.

Great protein sources:

- Chicken breast, turkey, lean beef
- Eggs and egg whites
- Greek yoghurt and cottage cheese
- Salmon, tuna, white fish
- Protein powder (whey or plant-based)
- Legumes and tofu (especially for plant-based eaters)

Calories — Are You Eating Enough?

Building muscle requires energy. If you're in a significant calorie deficit, your body will prioritise survival over muscle growth. For most women trying to build their glutes:

- Aggressive cut: muscle growth will be minimal to none
- Maintenance calories: slow growth possible, especially for beginners
- Small surplus (100–200 kcal above maintenance): optimal for lean muscle building

Carbohydrates — Your Training Fuel

Carbs fuel your workouts. Eating adequate carbohydrates before and after training supports performance, recovery, and muscle glycogen replenishment. Don't fear them — they're your friend when building.

The Peri-Workout Window

- Pre-workout (1–2 hours before): a balanced meal with protein and carbs
- Post-workout (within 2 hours): protein-rich meal or shake to kickstart recovery

Her Method Key Point

You cannot out-train poor nutrition. Glute growth requires both the right training stimulus AND the nutritional resources to build. Get your protein in, eat enough to support your training, and be consistent.

Chapter Seven

Recovery — Where Growth Actually Happens

Here's something that doesn't get talked about enough: your glutes don't grow during your workout. They grow after it, during recovery. The workout is just the signal. Recovery is where the magic happens.

Sleep

Sleep is your most powerful recovery tool. During deep sleep, your body releases growth hormone — the primary driver of muscle repair and growth. Chronic poor sleep directly impairs your body's ability to build muscle, even with perfect training and nutrition.

Aim for 7–9 hours of quality sleep per night. If you're not sleeping well, this should be your first priority.

Rest Days

Rest days are not wasted days. They're essential. Muscles need 48–72 hours to recover after a training session, which is why this program spaces sessions out. Training the same muscles every day prevents recovery and leads to overtraining — not more growth.

Stress Management

Chronic stress elevates cortisol levels, which can impair muscle growth and recovery. While you can't eliminate stress, managing it matters. Prioritise things that reduce your stress levels — even simple habits like walking outside, journalling, or reducing caffeine after midday can make a difference.

> **Her Method Key Point**
>
> The gym is just one piece of the puzzle. If your sleep is poor, your stress is high, or you're not resting enough between sessions, your results will be limited — no matter how hard you train.

You're Ready. Let's Build.

You now have everything you need to start building your glutes with intention and evidence behind every decision. Let me recap the key principles:

5. Train your glutes 2–3x per week with a mix of compound and isolation exercises
6. Progressively overload — track your lifts and aim to improve every session
7. Hit your protein target every single day (1.6–2.2g per kg)
8. Eat enough to support growth — a slight surplus is your friend
9. Prioritise sleep and recovery — this is where growth happens
10. Activate your glutes before every session for better connection and results

This guide is the starting point. If you want personalised coaching — a program built around your body, your schedule, and your goals — I'd love to work with you inside Her Method 1:1 coaching.

Every strong woman started somewhere. Let's build yours. — Khiana x

Ready to work together?

Apply for 1:1 coaching at hermethod.com

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